It is not entirely a coincidence that this northern rim and its extension in the Chhota Nagpur Plateau in the east is home to the bulk of India's tribal communities, known as the Scheduled Tribes (STs), less affected by developments and assimilations taking place around them throughout history. The STs constitute around 8 per cent of India's population today and they are also found in other hilly tracts such as the Himalayas, the hills of the Northeast and the desert landscape of west Rajasthan. It is their languages that make up the Austro-Asiatic group in central and eastern India and the Tibeto-Burman group in north-eastern India, two major language groups outside the Indo-European and Dravidian clusters, and which as per recent genetic research correspond to two distinct groups dubbed as the Ancestral Austro-Asiatic and Ancestral Tibeto-Burman.[11] Tribal migrations in ancient India ranged from nomadic hunter-gatherer formations to pastoralism and the exploration of greener pastures. At high altitudes, it also involved transhumance or the seasonal movement of people with their livestock between different altitudes.

If higher altitudes in difficult terrains restricted spatial mobility, or gave it a particular character in ancient India, the lower altitudes in conjunction with water through rainfall or rivers, supported more inmigration for agriculture-based settlements and the rise of rural population density, which as described in later chapters, had a definite impact in creating conditions for eventual outmigration. The coastal plains of India on both sides of the subcontinent, and especially the Kaveri delta of Tamil Nadu in south India, fall in this regional category, but they are miniscule in size compared to the great plains that lie between the Deccan Plateau and the Himalayas.

The Indo-Gangetic plain of over 600 million acres stretching from present-day Bangladesh in the east to Pakistan in the west is the most significant region from the point of view of the Indian subcontinent's political and demographic history. Most empires that have ruled the wide expanse of the subcontinent had their base there. It covers the fertile tracts of the rivers Indus and Ganga and their numerous tributaries, and is currently home to roughly 10 per cent of the world's population. The migrations that led to the settlement of this great plain before the Common